comprising Goa Football Association president Caitano Jose Fernandes, Indian Football Association secretary Anirban Dutta and Kerala Football Association president Navas Meeran—to engage the clubs and salvage the league. The clubs formed their own body, including representatives from NorthEast United FC, SC Delhi, Mohun Bagan Super Giant, Mumbai City FC and FC Goa. In the ensuing talks, a longer-term revenue-sharing solution was floated by the federation, under which the clubs would receive 50 per cent of the total revenue, the commercial rights-holder 30 per cent and the AIFF would retain a reduced stake, as well as a parachute fund for relegated teams. The proposal was received positively, but remains on the drawing board without a commercial partner.

That absence was underlined when the AIFF finally issued a Request for Proposal to identify a long-term commercial partner in October 2025. Five entities attended the pre-bid meeting, but not a single bid was submitted. Guaranteed annual payments pegged at Rs 37.5 crore over 15 years, judicial oversight, limited autonomy and unlimited risk made the tender commercially unattractive. That the previous operator FSDL absorbed losses of Rs 2,000–2,500 crore over the years is common knowledge.

FIGHT FOR SURVIVAL

The ISL is in full flow currently, with matches telecast on television and streaming on an OTT platform, but the 2025-26 edition is a shortened version. Fourteen teams as usual, but with a single round-robin and no playoffs—a half-season wearing full-season colours. The ISL was built as a broadcast product, with marquee rivalries and multiple playoffs that justified investment. The current plan is a round-robin sprint. "It feels like playing 90 minutes to decide a season," says a current ISL team captain. "You lose the grind that makes champions."

There is another cost too. The Asian Football Confederation (AFC) requires clubs to play at least 24 official matches across league and cup to earn direct entry in the AFC Champions League. With the

SOCCER FACES AN OBSTACLE COURSE

How various stakeholders in Indian football stand in this hour of crisis

ANI



SOCCER SUCCOUR Union minister of sports Mansukh Mandaviya with former Brazilian footballer Gilberto Silva during the FIFA World Cup 2026 trophy tour in Delhi, Jan. 10

↘ **All India Football Federation (AIFF):** Caught between court oversight, commercial paralysis and a history of infighting and litigation, the federation owns the ISL but lacks operational credibility, eroding trust among clubs, players, investors and international bodies alike

↘ **Indian Super League clubs:** Forced into survival mode, clubs absorbed losses, halted training, cut salaries and accepted a truncated format as the alternative—no football—meant erosion of player value and institutional relevance

↘ **Football Sports Development Ltd (FSDL):** The Reliance-backed FSDL once had sweeping rights over ISL and, some allege, over Indian football as a whole. After absorbing massive losses, it exited without a successor, leaving a vacuum that exposed the league's dependence on a single commercial pillar rather than a sustainable ecosystem



↘ **Professional players and coaches:** The most vulnerable stakeholders, they have endured unpaid wages, stalled careers and lost competitive rhythm, fitness and livelihoods, bearing the brunt of governance failures



↘ **Fans and broadcasters:** India's vast football audience adds to revenues of global leagues but largely ignores the domestic product, as inconsistency and administrative chaos prevent emotional/ financial commitment